

Grown-up's Playbook: The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle, warm tale with no villain at all: the only trouble is a happy muddle, and wisdom and kindness set it right every time.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village market.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Wisdom** (calm, clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red thread, a small bell or jingly thing for the little bell, and any small treat or token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- A handful of buttons, coins, or bricks in two or three colours makes the sorting in Stop 2 lovely and hands-on. It is not needed, but it helps.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Wisdom and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Wisdom).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these mountains, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox trots by and gives you one free hint.
2	You gather your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts through, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from the gate. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal floats down: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell, and for a moment everyone feels calm.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all. The trouble is only a friendly muddle made by Pon the Tanuki, who feels dreadful about it and most needs a kind word. The story is won by calming and reassuring Pon, by patiently sorting and counting the market back into place, and by helping Pon end the day proud rather than ashamed. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward kindness and clever thinking over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Jumbled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Pon the Tanuki sits in the middle of the toppled market, too upset and flustered to help. He has knocked everything over by accident and feels he has spoiled the festival. Before any tidying can begin, the players must calm and reassure him.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Kindness and Observation. The players notice that Pon is not naughty, only sad, and offer comfort: sitting beside him, telling him it was an accident, reminding him that everyone topples things sometimes, or promising that the muddle is smaller when friends fix it together. Sharing the rice cake works beautifully too. Any genuine kindness lifts his ears and gets him on his feet.

Fallback. If the children are unsure what to say, have Pon sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Do you think I am a bad tanuki?" A single warm "no" melts the worry at once. A friendly pat or a shared rice cake also does the trick, and Pon springs up, ready to help.

Stop 2: The Great Sort (Normal)

The challenge. Fans, fruit, and lanterns lie jumbled in one big heap. The players must sort, count, and match everything back to the right stall before the festival opens.

Intended solution. This is a Maths, Logic, and Observation moment. The clever move is to sort by kind first, then count and match. A worked example to guide them: make three piles, one for fans, one for fruit, one for lanterns. Fan out the fans on the fan stall. Sort the fruit by colour, the red plums into the red basket and the golden persimmons into the gold basket. Then count the lanterns onto the posts, the same number on each, say three posts with four lanterns each, twelve lanterns in all. Counting aloud together is the heart of this stop. Use buttons or bricks in colours if you have them, so small hands can sort for real.

Fallback. If the counting wobbles, do one pile together out loud and let them copy the pattern for the rest, or let Pon "remember" where one kind of thing goes. Spending an energy star to take a calm breath and start the pile again always works. Getting the market tidy with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Last Lantern (Normal)

The challenge. The market is nearly perfect, but the big red festival lantern that hangs over the centre is still missing, and the festival cannot begin without it. The players must follow a clue to find it, and help Pon feel proud rather than ashamed.

Intended solution. This is a Wisdom and Kindness moment. **Kon the Fox** offers the clue: something round and red rolled away, down the lane, under the old plum tree by the bridge. The clever players follow the clue and think where a runaway lantern likes to hide, and there it is, safe under the tree. Just as important, they let Pon join the search and be the one to spot the branch it caught on, so the day ends with Pon proud of helping rather than sorry for the muddle.

Fallback. If the clue is too tricky, have Kon make it plainer ("look low, near water, where the plums grow"), or let Pon catch a glimpse of red himself. However the lantern is found, make sure Pon gets the credit for the finding, so he ends the story standing tall.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a foe. When the last lantern is hung, the whole market glows, Pon the Tanuki is forgiven and proud, the drum beats and the festival opens, and **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** smiles down from the warm sky. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being wise, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.